

TALK LIKE A COACH

EVERYDAY CONVERSATIONS THAT
SHAPE YOUR TEAM AND SHARPEN
YOUR LEADERSHIP



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INTRODUCTION

Stop Giving Advice

I wish more people took your advice.

I'm sure it's great advice. I'm sure people would be better off if they did what you told them to do. I have no doubt it comes from a good place, and that you're only speaking up because you genuinely care about the other person. All these things can be true, and yet people are still resistant to being told what to do.

The problem, I've learned, isn't the quality of the advice but the attitude of the person receiving the message. It's the same reason why nobody washes a rental car. What's the point when there's no sense of ownership?

The question at the heart of this tension (and, to a greater extent, this entire book) is how to help people who resist being told what to do. We've tried giving advice, and it doesn't work. What else can we do?

Thankfully, there's another option. We can learn to guide developmental conversations in a way that invites engagement and ownership rather than resistance. But before we can do this, we need to take a dose of humility and adjust our expectations about who will get the credit.

The Star of the Show

Do you want to be the hero? The one who always knows exactly what to say and when to say it?

Most of us, if we're being honest, would say yes. At least a little.

This is especially true for those of us who are leaders, and it's not a character flaw. If anything, it's a reflection of how much we care. We want to support our people. We want to bring clarity in moments of uncertainty. We want to be seen as helpful, capable, and reliable so that others feel confident coming to us when they are stuck or unsure about what to do.

Usually, this type of behavior is rewarded. People praise our ideas and thank us for our quality answers. Over time, it's easy to internalize the belief that leadership means having the right answer at the right time and being ready to deliver it.

For me, this instinct was reinforced early on through my training as a preacher. I enjoyed accumulating ideas and figuring out how to share them with an audience in a way that was clear, compelling, and inspired action. The more I practiced, the more natural it felt.

What's interesting about preaching as a form of communication is that it tends to be one-sided by design. Questions exist, but they are not meant to be answered in real time (at least in most spaces). There's no room for real-time dialogue. You speak, others listen, and feedback, if there is any, doesn't come until you're off stage. That style of communication came naturally to me, and perhaps it does to you as well. Leadership, especially the kind that helps people grow, requires a much different approach. People will have questions. People will come to you for advice. People will bring you problems and expect you to know how to solve them in real time. When you have an answer, it feels really good. When you don't, you can quickly become unsure of yourself and your ability to contribute.

For a while, I resisted this tension. Lacking answers was revealing and uncomfortable. It left me questioning myself, my intelligence, and whether or not I had what it took to influence people.

Now, I lean into the discomfort. Adversity always reveals opportunity, especially in leadership. Wrestling with situations, such as moments where you're asked to provide an answer you don't have, serve as reminders of an essential truth about leadership: there is no perfect, one-size-fits-all approach that works for each person in each situation.

Leadership is always circumstantial. It lives at the intersection of who you are, who the other person is, and the context you're navigating together. No two people are exactly alike, which means no single answer works universally. Effective leadership requires flexibility, adaptability, and a willingness to meet people where they are and not where we wish they were.

This has been especially challenging for me because, in addition to having several years of preaching and teaching experience under my belt, I'm also naturally wired as an idea person. In conversations, I can't help but see solutions even when the other person didn't ask for them. I can find myself saying things like, "You didn't ask for any ideas, but here's something I thought of," or, "Have you thought about trying this?"

Over time, I began to realize that this instinct, while well-intentioned, could land in ways I didn't always intend or desire. What felt like generosity could be perceived as dominance or superiority on the other side. Even worse, it could quietly communicate, "I don't trust you to figure this out on your own."

I don't love admitting that. But it forced me to confront a deeper question: Who is this conversation really for?

Many leadership interactions default to a familiar pattern. A person brings a question. The leader provides the answer. Everyone moves on, and business continues as usual.

It feels efficient and productive, but that efficiency comes at a cost. When leaders consistently provide answers, they create dependency rather than ownership. The person receiving the advice may comply, but they haven't grown. If the solution doesn't work, blame may shift back to the leader. Even if it does work, the message is still received. Leaders share ideas and solve problems, while everyone else simply complies. Habits create beliefs, beliefs create culture, and culture impacts everything.

This is why so many leadership challenges feel repetitive. We tackle the same issues over and over, not because people aren't capable, but because we're hacking at branches instead of striking roots. Without a developmental approach, we can spend years addressing symptoms while the underlying patterns remain unchanged. People come to you with the same problems constantly, not because they are incapable of solving them on their own but because they assume you have a specific preference for what to do or how to do it.

The good news is it doesn't have to be this way. We don't need to quench our desire to be helpful. We simply need to add an extra set of tools to our toolbox. About seven years ago, I discovered that fresh approach in a way I didn't expect that I would.

In 2019, I had just stepped away from full-time ministry and wasn't sure what was next. I didn't know for sure what I wanted to do, but I knew it was time for a change. One day, my friend Spencer encouraged me to pursue coaching, saying I'd enjoy it and likely be good at it.

Immediately, I knew he wasn't talking about sports coaching, even in light of my high school JV baseball experience and my one season of indoor soccer in college. Still, I couldn't quite see myself in this role. I envisioned what a business coach would do and how they would help their clients, and a simple question emerged that felt like an insurmountable obstacle for me. How could I coach someone in business if I don't have business experience myself?

His response completely reframed how I understood leadership and development.

"It's actually better that way," he said. "Because you won't be telling them what to do. You'll be helping them find their own solutions."

That moment was paradigm shifting, and I still think about it almost every day.

I had been thinking about coaching the entirely wrong way. I assumed credibility came from experience, and believed I couldn't offer value unless I provided answers. Spencer's reframe taught me that coaching wasn't about providing the answers as much as it was helping people discover them. And by going through the coaching process, people wouldn't just find solutions to problems, but they would discover something good and capable about themselves that was always there, even if they didn't initially realize it.

The right question, asked at the right time, carries a kind of power that even the best advice can't duplicate. Advice is always external. Coaching helps uncover something internal. If people resisted advice because it wasn't theirs, perhaps coaching could be the vehicle that resulted in true ownership, action, and transformation.

This book is written for leaders who want to help their people grow without always being the one to save or rescue them. It's for the leader who doesn't care about being the hero, but who is patient and humble enough to partner with others in their growth and learning. Each person has tremendous innate potential, but that potential won't come out accidentally. However, you can be the person who helps others tap into it.

If I could go back and tell my younger self one thing about leadership conversations, it would be this: You don't have to have all the answers, and people won't think less of you if you don't. That truth took me longer to learn than I'd like to admit, but I'm grateful every day for discovering it.

To be clear, this book is not an argument against instruction, teaching, or advice. Those tools matter. There are moments when clarity, direction, and authority are exactly what the situation calls for. But if that's the only approach we ever take, our impact will always be limited. We need more than one tool, and I would argue that coaching is an essential tool for every leader's toolbox.

Like any tool, coaching has a purpose and a context. A Phillips screwdriver is incredibly useful, unless you're trying to hammer a nail. Learning when and how to talk like a coach gives leaders another option to help people move forward.

The irony is that talking like a coach initially creates more work. If you're expecting coaching to save time in the same way a calculator speeds up basic math equations, you're going to be disappointed. Our goal here isn't greater efficiency, but effectiveness.

When leaders shift from instructing to guiding, something powerful happens. People begin to think differently. They take ownership. They grow in confidence and adaptability. They stop waiting for permission and start exercising judgment. Good leaders may offer answers to

their team's questions, but great leaders develop people who can find answers to their own questions.

This book is an invitation to rethink how leadership shows up in everyday conversations. You're about to learn how you can guide people to their own answers, offering solutions that foster real action and ownership. This approach simultaneously solves short-term problems while also enhancing long-term growth and transformation. A win-win for everyone involved.

As you read, you may feel encouraged by what's possible and challenged by what it requires. This approach won't always feel natural. People may resist it. Some questions will land awkwardly. Many of them will work anyway. Remember that the power isn't in the question itself, but in the response the question creates.

If this book gives you better questions to ask that elicit better responses from the people you lead, it's done exactly what it's supposed to do. In the chapters to follow, I'm going to give you five questions that, when asked at the right time, can transform the experience people have under your leadership. My hope is that these questions aren't just conversational tools for you, but powerful reflections that help you see your own life and work differently as well. Before we get to these questions, we need to form a better understanding of coaching - what it is, what it's not, and why it's a more useful approach than teaching or giving advice in certain situations. Even if you don't plan to become a professional coach or hold formal coaching sessions, understanding how the process works will give you a better picture of how to use the questions and approaches we'll cover in the rest of the book.

A Basic Definition of Coaching

If you were to approach ten people on the street and ask what coaching is, there's a good chance you'd get ten different answers.

Some people would think of sports coaches. Others might describe a business consultant who walks into a situation, assesses what's broken, and tells you what to fix. Others might picture life coaches on social media who bring energy, optimism, and big talk about the future.

Those are some of the more positive images, but not everyone hears the word coaching that way. Some people assume coaching is soft, slow, or disconnected from real-world demands. They picture conversations full of vague encouragement or lofty ideas that never translate into action. Others feel suspicious of coaches who speak in broad generalizations without any lived experience in the problems they're trying to address.

Here's the problem with all of these images, both the good and the bad: they only capture a small slice of what coaching actually is. Before we talk about how to incorporate coaching skills into your leadership, we need a shared understanding of what coaching is, what it isn't, and why it works the way it does.

This section may feel more detailed than others in the book, especially if you are not interested in becoming a professional coach. That's fine. You don't have to be. What follows is not about mastering a new discipline, but about understanding the mechanics behind conversations that help people think more clearly, take ownership, and move forward.

If the rest of this book is about how to talk like a coach, this is the part that helps you understand why those conversations are different.

Your First Experience With Coaching

When I'm asked to explain coaching in organizations or conference settings, my preference is not only to describe it but to help people experience it. Some coaches do live demonstrations, and I've done them before. They can be useful, but I'd rather give everyone the chance to feel what coaching does inside their own mind instead of watching it happen for someone else.

I do that by asking ten coaching-style questions one at a time and encouraging everyone to write down their answers. The questions are simple:

- What's something I would like to work on?
- What do I want to take away from this reflection?
- Why is this important to me right now?
- How do I want this to look six to twelve months from now?
- What skills or mindsets do I need to develop to handle this well?
- What's the first step I can take to improve?
- What will be most challenging about moving forward?
- What or who could help me address this challenge?
- What will I commit to doing?
- How will I ensure it actually gets done?

Before we proceed, I'd encourage you to pause and answer each of these for yourself. You'll get a better grasp on how coaching works, and hopefully some helpful insight about a relevant topic that you can immediately put into practice.

My goal in this exercise is to reveal three things about coaching. First, coaching generates something new inside the person being coached. As people answer each question, they begin having ideas, connections, and realizations that were not as clear before the question was asked. Those thoughts were already there, but the right question helped bring them to the surface.

Second, coaching creates customized action plans. The first half of these questions is about awareness and perspective, but the second half of questions makes those new ideas practical. Many people want to skip straight to action steps because they feel productive. Coaching slows that down just enough to make sure the action actually solves the right problem.

Third, coaching helps lock in progress through meaningful accountability. This does not have to come from the coach, although ongoing coaching does offer a form of inherent accountability. Often, the most effective accountability comes from helping the person design their own system for follow-through. That's why I'm less likely to ask, "How can I hold you accountable?" and more likely to ask, "What kind of accountability will help you follow through?"

With that foundation in place, we can define coaching more clearly and understand what sets it apart from other styles of communication.

A Basic Definition of Coaching

The International Coaching Federation (ICF) defines coaching this way: “Coaching is partnering with clients in a thought-provoking and creative process that inspires them to maximize their personal and professional potential.”

This definition is dense, but in the best possible way. As I read it, four words catch my attention as a reflection of what happens when somebody is coached. If you keep these four words in mind, you’ll begin to recognize what sort of impact coaching can have, even in everyday leadership conversations that wouldn’t be considered “formal” coaching sessions.

Coaching Is a Partnership

Advice is often one-sided. The person asking for it is typically looking for an answer they can apply quickly with minimal adaptation or reflection. The same can’t be said for coaching.

Coaching is a partnership, which means both people have a role to play. In order for the coaching process to produce the best possible result, both sides must pull their weight. The coach is responsible for listening well, asking good questions, and structuring the conversation in a way that supports the person’s goals. The other person is responsible for engaging honestly, thinking deeply, and taking ownership of what they choose to do afterwards.

In other words, the power of coaching doesn’t come from the coach’s brilliance or the coachee’s motivation alone, but from the partnership between both parties. When both sides show up fully, the results can be significant. When someone refuses to engage, coaching loses most of its impact.

This is what people mean when they say someone is “coachable.” It does not mean they are easy or agreeable. It means they are willing to take ownership of their thinking and behavior.

If you’re a leader, this matters. Coaching is not something you do to people – it’s something you do with them. As you begin to incorporate a coach approach into your everyday leadership conversations, there may be times when you have to explain what you’re doing and why you’re doing it so that people can develop proper expectations and express buy-in.

Coaching is a Process

Effective coaching is not random, nor is it simply asking questions until someone stumbles into a breakthrough. Coaching follows a process designed to move a person from clarity to action.

One simple way to understand that process is through the Four A's:

- Agreement: What are we focusing on?
- Awareness: What is really going on here?
- Action: What will we do next?
- Accountability: How will we ensure it gets done?

If you look back at the ten questions from the self-guided activity, you'll notice they follow this arc. Questions one and two define the agreement. Questions three, four, and five evoke new awareness. Questions six, seven, and eight develop the action plan, and questions nine and ten help lock in the action plan through the creation of accountability.

You don't have to follow this structure rigidly, but you do need to understand the logic of it. Many leadership conversations become unhelpful because they jump to action without setting an agreement or cultivating new awareness. Leaders rush to solve problems before they truly understand what the person is facing or what the person actually wants.

That is one reason coaching works. It slows you down just enough to aim at the right target. There are other models that can be helpful beyond this one, but coaching always works best when it follows a process.

Coaching Inspires

Our English word inspire comes from the Latin *inspirare*, which means "to breathe into." Historically, words like breath, wind, and spirit were often used interchangeably to describe something unseen but powerful that moves, animates, and creates motion.

If you're familiar with the creation story in the Hebrew Bible, you may remember the moment in Genesis 2 when God breathes life into Adam's lungs. That breath marks the beginning of life. A similar idea shows up in the New Testament letter of 2 Timothy, where some translations describe Scripture as "God-breathed," while others use the phrase "inspired by God." The words are different, but the meaning is the same. Something breathed into something else, bringing life and movement with it.

We're not here to debate theology or argue for one religion over another, but it's clear that the language of inspiration has long pointed to something powerful taking place, whether it's the beginning of new life or the force and movement carried by the wind.

Coaching can have a similar effect. Not because a coach is “breathing life” into someone in a dramatic way, but because the right conversation can do something subtle and profound. It can bring energy where someone has been stuck. It can create movement where old patterns have kept them stalled. It can help a person see possibilities they couldn't see before, and step into a new way of thinking that changes what they do next.

Coaching Unlocks Potential

Potential is one of my favorite words in the English language because it represents what could be, even if it does not exist yet.

Every person you lead has more in them than they are currently expressing. Sometimes it's skill. Sometimes it's confidence. Sometimes it's judgment or courage. Often it's all of the above.

Coaching is a tool that helps uncover what is already present but unrecognizable or underdeveloped. It assumes that the best solution for one person might not be the best solution for someone else. Rather than forcing people into a predetermined answer, coaching helps them uncover their best path forward and then take ownership of it.

That is why coaching can be so powerful in leadership contexts. It's not trying to make a person into something they are not. Instead, it's helping them become the best version of who they already are. And in the next section, we'll cover the basic skills that will help you determine how to access this potential. To an extent, you're already doing each of these things, but there's opportunities for all of us to do them more often or more effectively.

Basic Coaching Skills

The impact of coaching is profound, but the skills behind it are surprisingly simple. This doesn't mean they are easy, but they certainly aren't rocket science.

At its core, coaching is built on a few foundational practices. When you improve in these, your everyday leadership conversations improve with them.

Listening Actively

Listening well is the foundation of coaching. Many of us assume listening is passive, but as Chris Voss writes in *Never Split the Difference*, it's one of the most active things we do.

Good listening takes effort. It requires attention, curiosity, restraint, focus, empathy, and genuine care for the other person. Agreeing with what the other person is saying isn't mandatory; rather, understanding is our goal.

Coaches are trained to listen beyond words. That includes tone, pacing, energy, word choice, and what someone avoids saying. Often, these things reveal assumptions or fears the person hasn't named yet.

As a leader, active listening helps you avoid the temptation to solve the wrong problem. It helps you hear what is actually being asked, not just what is being said.

A simple leadership move that often works is reflecting what you heard and asking if you got it right. That may sound basic, but it shows that you care about hearing what the other person says and getting it right. It's also an opportunity for the other person to hear how they are coming across and confirm if it's what they intended.

Asking Powerful Questions

One of the most important lessons I ever learned is that questions drive thinking. For years, I carried a quiet assumption that people who ask questions are less intelligent, as if questions exist only because someone does not know what they should know.

That belief was completely wrong. Questions are not a weakness, but a superpower. The right question asked at the right time can change everything - especially in a coaching conversation.

So how do we know which questions are the right questions? The best questions come from active listening. If we're in tune with what the coachee is saying, we won't have to work hard to come up with quality questions - they will simply arise within the context of the conversation.

A good rule of thumb is that coaching questions should be open-ended, or questions that can't be answered with a simple "yes" or "no." Another helpful distinction is the difference between test questions and discovery questions. Test questions have a clear right and wrong answer. Such as "what is two plus two" or "what is the capital of Oklahoma" aren't questions that allow for nuance or difference in interpretation. Discovery questions, on the other hand, create insight by asking people to explore what they think, what they want, what they value, and what they are willing to do next.

When we hear a discovery question, we may not know the answer immediately. However, with reflection, we can quickly generate new thoughts. A question like, "What do you want

your life to be like one year from now” or “Who are three people you admire and what do you admire about them” may be questions that take a moment to process, but it’s where new thoughts and ideas come from.

Remember, your questions do not have to be impressive. In fact, the more “normal” your questions are, the more usable they become in everyday conversations. Questions like:

- What do you mean by that?
- What feels most important here?
- What would success look like?
- What’s making this hard?
- What options do you see?

The goal is not to sound like a coach, but to create the kind of thinking that helps someone take ownership. Rather than telling people how they should think, you’ll begin helping them understand how they really do think.

Defining the Agreement

Defining the agreement simply means clarifying what you are focusing on and what the person wants out of the conversation. For example, imagine someone brings you a time management concern. The overall goal might be building a sustainable schedule or accomplishing a few key tasks or projects. Still, the goal of this particular conversation might be more specific. Maybe they need help clarifying priorities, eliminating distractions, or deciding what to say no to.

Naming that focus up front does two things. It creates clarity about what success looks like in the conversation and what direction both coach and coachee are moving in. It also gives you a checkpoint you can return to if the conversation drifts. Many conversations feel unproductive not because the topic is unimportant, but because there is no shared clarity about what would make the conversation successful.

If you adopt only one coaching skill quickly, this is a great place to start. This skill is one of the most practical tools you can carry into everyday leadership conversations - not only conversations that offer development opportunities, but also weekly one-on-ones, regular staff meetings, and other strategic conversations. What would happen if all of these conversations featured a shared expectation of what the overall goal or focus was?

Formal vs. Informal Coaching

So far, much of what we've discussed could apply to formal coaching sessions. You may be thinking, "This makes sense in a scheduled conversation, but how does it translate to the real world of quick questions, deadlines, and constant interruptions?"

It translates because you do not need a formal coaching session to use a coaching approach. Every leader can ask better questions. Every leader can listen more intentionally. Every leader can clarify the purpose of a conversation before jumping to solutions.

When you begin practicing this, it may feel awkward at first. That's normal. You may feel like you are "doing coaching" rather than simply leading. Over time, that feeling fades. The skills become more natural, to the point where you utilize them without even thinking about what you're doing. This is unconscious competence, and it won't happen without the necessary practice reps and occasional mistakes.

Regardless, you are not becoming a professional coach. You are becoming the kind of leader who can help people think, own their development, and move forward without needing you to rescue them every time.

In the chapters that follow, we'll explore five shifts that will sharpen how you lead through everyday conversations. Keep these foundations in mind as you read. The goal is not to replace instruction or authority. The goal is to add another tool, one that develops people rather than creating dependence.

SHIFT ONE

Stop Trying to Fix Everything

“All time management is pain management.”

This line from Nir Eyal’s book *Indistractable* has stayed with me ever since I first read it.

At first, I resisted it. I’ve always considered myself a positive and optimistic person, and the idea that so much of my behavior might be driven by avoiding discomfort felt overly cynical. I didn’t like the implication that my decisions were less about values and more about escape.

But the longer I sat with it, the harder it became to dismiss. And if this is true for me, it’s likely true for you and for the people you lead as well.

What if much of what we do each day really is about managing discomfort? What if our choices, habits, and even our leadership behaviors are shaped less by what we want most and more by what we’re trying to avoid in the moment?

Seen through that lens, life begins to resemble a long series of problems we are attempting to solve. Some are obvious and urgent, while others remain quietly in the background. Nearly every decision we make is a response to something, whether pressure, uncertainty, boredom, or something else.

If everything we do is an attempt to solve a problem, then an important question follows naturally: are we solving the right problems?

The Tension Between Now and Later

I’m not sure how well I would get along with my future self, and I know I wouldn’t always see eye to eye with my past self.

It’s not that I’ve ever had bad intentions. I don’t question my character or values. What I recognize, though, is that my priorities have shifted over time. My future self cares about things my present self often discounts, just as my past self cared about things that no longer carry the same weight today.

This tension shows up clearly in motivation. In my book *Motivation for Regular People*, I contrasted long-term goals with short-term desires. My future self wants to be in excellent physical shape. My present self wants to eat a pint of cookies and cream ice cream and sleep in instead of getting up early to go to the gym.

Leadership operates under the same tension. Your present self takes pride in being helpful. You answer questions, fix mistakes, solve problems, and keep things moving. Even when you genuinely want others to take initiative, it often feels more efficient to step in and do the work yourself rather than wait.

The challenge is that what produces a positive short-term result doesn't always lead to the best long-term outcome. Or, as the world-renowned psychologist Taylor Swift once observed, band-aids don't fix bullet holes.

Management Feels Responsible. Leadership Feels Risky.

What's the difference between leadership and management?

At first glance, the two can appear interchangeable. We often use the terms without pausing to consider the assumptions embedded in each. In my work, I tend to be cautious with the word management, not because it's wrong, but because it can quietly narrow our understanding of what leadership is meant to accomplish.

Management is often defined as the process of controlling or maintaining systems and people. The emphasis is on order, efficiency, and stability. These are important responsibilities, and there are moments when leaders must step into this role. But when management becomes the dominant posture, it limits growth.

As a lifelong football fan, I think of the quarterback described as a "game manager" or "bus driver." This player is competent and reliable. They won't lose the game, but they're unlikely to elevate the team to its full potential or unlock something new.

Leadership requires a different posture. When I talk about leadership, I often define it as the intersection of goals and people. A leader believes tomorrow can be better than today and is willing to bring others along for that journey. Rather than preserving the status quo, they are motivated by growth and development.

This kind of leadership has the power to transform organizations and change lives. At the same time, it often runs counter to what workplaces reward, especially early in a leader's career.

Many leaders are promoted because they are excellent problem solvers. They step in, clean things up, and keep everything running. That skill matters, but it is not sufficient. Managing systems may keep things functioning, but leadership helps people become better tomorrow than they are today.

The difficulty is that leadership progress often feels slower and less predictable. In a world shaped by instant gratification, what feels urgent tends to crowd out what is most important. This shows up in leaders who answer every question, make every decision, and intervene at the first sign of confusion. The work gets done, but the organization isn't moving toward something better.

There's also no such thing as passive maintenance. Systems either improve or deteriorate over time. Think about your house or your car. Without intentional care, quality declines. The same is true for teams.

When leaders feel responsible for answering every question and solving every problem, people are rarely challenged to think deeply or take ownership. Over time, the leader becomes indispensable, not because they are inspiring, but because they have created a system that cannot function without them. It may work today, but it is unsustainable tomorrow.

Short-term thinking trains teams to be reactive rather than proactive. It prioritizes relief over growth, stability over development, and comfort over progress. These patterns don't emerge because leaders don't care. In many cases, the opposite is true. Stepping in often feels compassionate and responsible.

But leadership requires leaders to trade short-term comfort for long-term growth. It requires a willingness to tolerate tension, ambiguity, and less obvious results in service of building capacity for tomorrow.

Why Long-Term Thinking Is So Hard

If long-term thinking is so beneficial, why does it feel so difficult?

Part of the answer is biological. The human brain evolved to help us survive immediate threats, not to plan years into the future. For most of human history, short-term thinking was responsible thinking.

But we no longer live in that environment. Most of us are not worried about predators or finding our next meal. We have stability and resources that allow us to think beyond survival, even though our instincts haven't fully caught up with that reality.

As a result, we tend to overestimate what can be accomplished quickly and underestimate what's possible through consistent, patient effort. Craig Groeschel captures this well when he says we often grossly overestimate the short term while grossly underestimating the long term.

Leadership invites us to correct that distortion. One of my favorite coaching questions does exactly that: What do you want this to look like in five years?

That question immediately changes the tone of a conversation. It pulls people out of urgency and into perspective. It creates space to consider what truly matters, not just what feels loudest in the moment.

It also reveals something important. Many of the problems we feel most anxious to solve today lose their intensity when viewed through a longer horizon. They may still matter, but we think about them differently.

Long-term thinking helps us choose solutions not because they make today easier, but because they make the future better.

Choosing a Destination Changes Everything

Thinking long-term forces us to choose a destination before we obsess over the path.

When we know where we want to go, priorities clarify. Distractions lose power. Energy becomes focused. Without a destination, people default to motion rather than progress.

But vision alone isn't enough. Vision without traction can feel overwhelming.

This is where many leaders get stuck. They can imagine a better future but don't know how to bridge the gap between where they are and where they want to be.

One framework I've found helpful comes from James Clear's work on habits. He calls it the ABZ framework.

- Z is the destination.
- A is where you are right now.
- B is the next step.

The mistake many people make is focusing only on A and Z. When we do that, the gap feels overwhelming, like progress requires a dramatic leap. In reality, progress rarely works that way.

B is the step that moves you from zero to one percent. It often feels almost too small to matter. In coaching conversations, I'll ask people to name a step so small they wonder if it should even count. More often than not, that's the right place to start.

For leaders, ABZ offers relief and agency. Relief from the pressure to overhaul everything overnight, and agency in realizing that small, intentional shifts compound over time.

Talking Long-Term With Your Team

Long-term thinking is not a perspective most people adopt immediately. Change requires effort, and resistance is a normal human response. That doesn't mean change is impossible.

Human beings are remarkably adaptable. Our brains are capable of forming new patterns of thinking, and growth is always part of the human experience.

The same is true for teams.

Long-term thinking doesn't take hold overnight, but it can be cultivated with intention. One practical place to start is by talking openly about the future and inviting people to imagine what they want it to look like. Peter Drucker famously observed that everything is created twice, first in the mind and then in reality. Long-term thinking allows you to be intentional about that first creation.

It's also important to remember that the best lessons are often caught, not taught. If you want your team to think long-term, they need to see it modeled. That means explaining your decisions, naming tradeoffs, and staying hopeful even when growth requires discomfort.

Finally, use long-term language in everyday conversations. When people bring you problems or opportunities, ask questions that widen the horizon. Questions like, What do you want this to look like down the road? invite a different kind of thinking and often unlock clarity that urgency obscures.

Where This Leaves You

If you feel tension as you read this, that's a good sign. This shift isn't meant to shame you or invalidate how you've led in the past. It's meant to expand your options.

You don't have to abandon urgency, but you do need to put it in its place. You don't have to stop managing, but you do need to lead.

You don't need to master long-term thinking overnight. You simply need to start. Define your Z. Be honest about your A. Choose your B.

It doesn't have to be perfect. It just has to move you forward.

Assume You're Missing Something Important

“You’re too young to feel burned out. I’ve been doing what I’ve been doing for years, and I’ve never felt that way.”

I heard those words nearly seven years ago. They don’t sting the way they once did, but I still remember exactly how they landed in that moment.

At the time, I was working in youth ministry and coming off my first summer as both a youth minister and a parent. It was the hardest summer of my life. Once over the course of those months, I spent seventeen consecutive days away from my wife and my ten-month-old son. FaceTime helped, but there were moments while I was traveling when I genuinely wondered if my son would recognize me when I finally came home.

Even when I was home, I wasn’t really there. The physical and mental demands of my job followed me everywhere. My mind stayed tethered to work during the hours that were supposed to be reserved for rest and family. It didn’t feel sustainable, and it seemed inevitable that something was going to give.

That reality hit me toward the end of the summer. The calendar finally cleared. The trips and events were behind me, and I welcomed the chance for extended rest. But something unexpected happened. Even after several uninterrupted nights at home and meaningful time away from the office, the motivation and energy I normally relied on didn’t return. For the first time, I couldn’t refill my cup, no matter what I tried.

That’s when I started reading about burnout. I had heard the term many times before, but I never imagined it would apply to me. The more I learned about the signs and symptoms, the more uncomfortable the recognition became. I saw myself in the descriptions.

One suggestion I came across was to talk honestly with someone I trusted. I met regularly with a leader at the church and felt safe enough to be vulnerable. So over lunch one day, I shared something I hadn’t voiced to anyone besides my wife. I wasn’t looking for answers. I was hoping for understanding, and maybe even a lifeline. Instead, I was shut down.

Four days later, I was called into the church and told I was no longer the right fit for the role. The church would be parting ways with me.

The months that followed were among the most challenging seasons of my life. And yet, looking back, I'm deeply grateful for that time. It gave me space to get healthy, to regain clarity, and to discern what my next steps should be without the constant pressure to perform in a role that had begun to drain me faster than I could keep up with.

I don't share this story to ask for sympathy, and I don't harbor resentment toward the church for the decision they made. My life unfolded exactly the way it needed to. I share it because it illustrates something leaders too easily forget.

The people we lead are not robots.

Each person under our leadership is a human being with competing responsibilities, private struggles, and unseen pressures. They bring all of that into the workplace, whether they intend to or not. Leading people well requires more than direction and accountability. It requires empathy, curiosity, understanding, and patience.

This doesn't mean underperformance should be ignored, or that hard decisions should never be made. Leadership sometimes requires discipline, redirection, or even separation. But it's important to recognize the weight of what leadership actually is. To lead someone is to influence their livelihood, their confidence, their sense of identity, and, sometimes, the trajectory of their life.

That responsibility isn't something we get to debate away. We can only acknowledge it and choose how we carry it.

As a leader, you're dealing with this every day whether you realize it or not. Every 1-on-1, performance review, staff meeting, and quick hallway chat reflects a conversation with a human being with insecurities, baggage, fears, dreams, and wishes. How we make sense of what we're seeing determines how we respond, and whether we choose to approach situations with judgment or curiosity can quickly magnify (or diminish) the impact of our leadership.

One of the first lessons I learned in coach training was to avoid asking questions if I already knew the answer. My trainers joked that a lawyer usually wouldn't ask a question if they didn't already know the answer, but argued that a coach's approach should be exactly the opposite. The best questions are the ones that we don't yet know how to answer, and chances are good that the person we're coaching doesn't yet know, either. This is where new ideas and thoughts are generated.

Asking questions like these requires a posture of humility and an assumption that we don't yet know everything there is to know. Questions like, "What am I missing?" Or, "What do I not

yet see?” are likely not questions I would ask in a coaching session because the goal of the conversation is not for me to have complete understanding as the coach. I’m more concerned with the client’s understanding of the issue at hand.

However, I think these questions are crucial for the leader who wants to empower their people and promote a culture of curiosity, partnership, and influence-based leadership rather than relying on titles, authority, or blind trust.

In the book *Perceptual Intelligence*, Eric Van Alstyne argues that what we see influences how we feel, which influences how we act. Too often, leaders jump ahead to feelings in conversations, which can easily be perceived as confrontational. These are the statements that are more likely to begin with “you” than “I.” You can see how this would be perceived as judgmental or accusatory.

To believe that what we see influences what we feel is to acknowledge two truths. First, there’s a gap between perception and feelings that is worth addressing, and perhaps we control our feelings more than we initially acknowledge (more on control later when we talk about Shift Three). Next, when we phrase interpretations based on what we see rather than what we feel, we acknowledge that our opinion can change if we see something different. This is what the authors of *Crucial Conversations* were alluding to when they discussed the concept of adding to the “shared pool of meaning” as a way of gaining full context and understanding before coming to a decision or a verdict.

Leading this way invites conversation rather than compliance. Think back on the interaction I had with my leader during my time in ministry. If he had exercised patience and slowed down to ask questions about what he was missing from my story, or acknowledged what he saw rather than jumping straight to what he was feeling, the conversation would have played out in a way that was much more positive and supportive than what ultimately happened. It may feel like extra work, but it reflects a desire to cultivate trust and lead with people rather than against people. To put it simply, you can’t treat people like tasks to cross off a to-do list. People are more dynamic than that, which means that leadership will always be more complex than it appears.

To put this concept into practice requires you to acknowledge that you don’t see everything and, if you’re being honest, you can’t see most things. As I sit and type this chapter, I can see my computer, my desk, and, thanks to my peripheral vision, a small portion of the area around my desk. I cannot see the door to the room, nor can I see all the furniture behind me. There’s a lot that I cannot physically see unless I slow down and change my perspective. If that’s true about my surroundings, imagine how much more true it is about the people I surround myself with and interact with on a daily basis. I often tell people in training sessions

that we see deeply inside ourselves but only surface level within others. There's a lot that we don't know about people, and we won't discover any of it if we aren't willing to slow down long enough to get curious and imagine what we're missing. You'll find the words here easy to implement into everyday conversations. Questions like, what am I missing, what else do I need to know about this, and what can I not see from my perspective are easy to verbalize. What's challenging is slowing down long enough to listen to the answer and being willing to shift your perspective based on what you've learned. It's going to require the creation of new neuropathways, new filters, and new expectations. You may prefer the old way of how you saw things, like when Toby Keith recorded his hit single "Wish I Didn't Know Now" with the popular refrain, "I wish I didn't know now what I didn't know then." The issue is, you do know now, and it's your responsibility to choose how you respond.

At the end of the day, leadership isn't about having all the answers. It's about creating environments where people feel heard, valued, and respected. That doesn't mean avoiding hard conversations or lowering expectations. It means slowing down long enough to understand the person in front of you before deciding what comes next.

When leaders assume they're missing something important, conversations change. Trust grows. Defensiveness fades. Collaboration increases. And over time, teams learn to lead themselves with the same curiosity and care they have experienced.

That's the quiet power of this shift, and it's one of the most practical ways leaders can begin talking like a coach.

SHIFT THREE

Accept Responsibility (Even When It's Not Your Fault)

Two years ago, I had two conversations with two different leaders on the same day, and they couldn't have been more different.

The first leader was navigating the exit of a key staff member. On the surface, it was a difficult situation, and one that would test anyone's leadership. But as we talked, it became clear that the issue wasn't simply the departure itself. It was how he was responding to it.

He was dragging his feet on communicating the situation to the rest of the team, choosing instead to act as if everything were business as usual. I couldn't tell whether he was afraid to confront reality or quietly hoping that, if he ignored the problem long enough, it would resolve itself on its own.

What concerned me most was the shift I noticed in him. He wasn't following through on plans we had discussed in earlier conversations, and his demeanor felt noticeably more guarded and rigid. As we talked through the situation, he offered explanation after explanation for why his approach made sense. He cited reasons for everything he was doing and seemed to feel completely validated in his decisions.

What he didn't have was much curiosity about where his thinking might be incomplete or where his own actions might be contributing to the tension. There was a lot of justification, but very little ownership.

Later that same day, I sat across from another leader who was dealing with a completely different situation and carrying himself in a completely different way. He was struggling with a team member and felt uneasy about how their recent conversations had gone. He could clearly articulate areas where the other person needed to grow, and he didn't minimize the challenge. But he didn't stop there. At one point, he paused and said something along the lines of, "I keep wondering if there's a better way I could be handling this."

He didn't see himself as blameless, nor did he excuse the other person's behavior. Instead, he held himself to the same standard he expected from his team. He was genuinely committed to growth, even when that meant turning the focus inward.

Both leaders were facing a challenge that all of us encounter at some point: the reality that we can't control everything about people or situations. The difference wasn't experience, intelligence, or authority. It came down to each leader's willingness (or lack thereof) to accept responsibility for what they could control.

What Happens When We Lack Control

Have you ever stopped to think about all the things in life you can't control?

The weather. Traffic. Other people's decisions. The past. Whether people post pictures of themselves on social media with dog ears and noses.

I added that last one to inject a little humor into a topic that otherwise wouldn't be very enjoyable. But the truth is, as frustrating as it can feel to think about what's outside of our control, most of us can't help but fixate on those things. And it's not hard to see why. These factors often affect us directly, and we're usually the ones who end up paying the price.

One of the biggest problems is that we subconsciously default to worry as a false sense of control. We can't actually change the situation, but by thinking through every possible negative outcome, we convince ourselves that we're being responsible. In reality, we're often just exhausting ourselves and robbing the present moment of its potential.

We bring this same mentality into problem-solving and leadership more often than we realize. When something isn't working, our instinct is usually to look outward first. We blame circumstances. We point fingers. We wish things were different. All of that feels easier (and safer) than turning inward and asking what might need to change in us.

There are understandable reasons for this. It's more comfortable to assume the problem is outside of us than to examine our own blind spots or limitations. Self-justification helps us feel validated. It protects our ego. And in many cases, it allows us to stay exactly where we are.

There's also a harder truth we don't always want to acknowledge: sometimes the situation really isn't our fault. That's where resistance tends to show up.

We struggle with the idea of cleaning up a mess we didn't make, even when we agree that things would be better if the mess were dealt with. We're working through this reality in our own home with our kids. We value a reasonably clean house - it doesn't have to be perfect, but we don't want to step on Legos or find yesterday's dirty dishes on the living room floor.

When it's time to pick up, our kids sometimes push back, frustrated that they're being asked to clean up toys or trash that isn't theirs. Our response is simple and consistent: we all pick up messes we didn't make sometimes. It's part of living with other people. We carry one another's burdens. Sometimes we benefit from that arrangement. Other times, it costs us something.

Leadership works the same way. Mark Manson describes this dynamic as choosing responsibility over blame. When trouble arises, figuring out who's at fault often becomes wasted energy. The goal shifts from making the situation better to proving our innocence. It might boost our ego, but it rarely leads to progress.

As leaders, our job isn't to assign blame and wash our hands of the situation. It's to take responsibility for what we can control.

Responsibility Without Resentment

This distinction became very real for me a few years ago while working on a large project for a client.

On the day of a training, we faced a challenge we couldn't have anticipated or prepared for. The client was understandably unhappy with the result, and we were committed to making it right.

Internally, though, we felt frustrated. We had done the best we could with the information and resources we had at the time, and yet we were still dealing with the consequences of circumstances outside our control.

In a conversation with a partner I was working with, I found myself articulating something that clarified the situation for both of us: we were not at fault for what happened, but we were responsible for addressing it.

That distinction mattered. It shifted our mindset from defensiveness to ownership, from resentment to problem-solving. Instead of fixating on what went wrong or who was to blame, we focused on what we could do next to restore trust and move forward.

That's the principle at the heart of this shift. Leaders are responsible for accepting responsibility for what they can control, not for resenting what they can't.

This inward posture does more than create better outcomes. It creates space for peace. When leaders stop fighting reality and start working within it, energy that was once wasted on frustration becomes available for progress.

The Coaching Question That Re-Centers the Conversation

Learning to think like a coach requires an intentional shift in attention from what we can't control to what we can.

In coaching conversations, clients frequently want to talk through situations that lie partially (or entirely) outside of their control. Most often, these situations involve relationships. When that happens, I'll gently remind them that while every relationship has at least two sides, there is only one side they can control.

That reminder naturally leads to one of my favorite coaching questions: what about this situation do you control?

I love this question because it doesn't minimize complexity or deny unfairness. It simply brings clarity. We may not be able to control everything, but there are always elements that remain within our influence.

- We can't control the weather, but we can choose what we wear and whether we prepare for it.
- We can't dictate traffic, but we can decide how we use the time. We can listen to an audiobook, a podcast, or simply sit with our thoughts before the day gets busy.
- We can't control other people's decisions, but we can choose what we believe about them, their values, and their intentions.

Over time, this question changes how leaders think. In the short term, it helps them regain a sense of agency. In the long term, it trains their instincts toward proactive, solution-oriented thinking. Problems stop feeling paralyzing because attention is no longer trapped on what should be different. It's focused on what can be done.

This doesn't mean external circumstances don't matter. They do. It's healthy to acknowledge preferences, desires, and disappointment. But leadership requires the ability to move forward even when reality doesn't align with expectations.

When leaders focus on what they can do, rather than what they wish others would do, a sense of agency and an opportunity to make a difference is always within reach.

Making the Shift Practical

If you want to practice this shift intentionally, here's a simple framework to start with.

- First, identify what you can't control. Naming these realities doesn't give them more power; it simply helps you see the situation clearly so you can respond intentionally.
- Second, accept that you can't control them. Holding onto frustration or resentment isn't productive. That energy can be used more effectively.
- Finally, acknowledge what you can control. Even small actions restore agency. They remind you that you're not stuck, even if the situation hasn't fully resolved.

This shift will naturally show up in your conversations with your team. In the story I referenced at the beginning of the chapter, I didn't have to ask either leader what their thoughts were on what they couldn't control. It was confirmed with their actions. One opted for blame, ignorance, and resentment. The other was willing to look in the mirror, even when it was uncomfortable, to acknowledge opportunities for growth and recognize that we don't always come across exactly in the way that we want.

Once you make this shift, people will begin to quickly notice. As a small expression of vulnerability, this will create trust and strengthen relationships. Additionally, it will afford you opportunities to help people make a similar shift. Conversations that would otherwise result in gossip, finger-pointing, and endless complaining will be forever transformed as you learn how to gently but effectively challenge your team to choose responsibility and ownership instead.

Over time, this way of thinking becomes a mindset, one of your most valuable assets in the face of uncertainty. And when leaders model this posture consistently, the impact extends beyond themselves. Teams learn responsibility not because they're told to, but because they see it lived out. You begin to

It's time to stop asking questions like, "Why is this happening to me?" or "Why can't this be easier?" Those questions may be understandable, but they drain energy without creating movement. They keep our attention fixed on what's missing rather than what's possible.

A different set of questions opens a different path: "What about this can I control?" and "What is being asked of me here?" do more than help you navigate difficult moments. They shape how you show up in conversations. They influence how your team responds under pressure. And they quietly determine the kind of leader you become.

Make The Tough Decisions Before You Feel Ready

“How much confidence do you need to make a decision?”

Silence. Not an awkward silence, but a powerful one.

I was coaching a leader who was trying to process some feedback he had recently received. His manager told him that he had good ideas, and that he could benefit from acting on more of those ideas.

Overall, the feedback was positive, but my client was struggling with how to make it actionable. It wasn't that he lacked confidence in his ideas, but he also valued certainty and wanted to avoid unnecessary risk. Sometimes, he felt the urge to weigh the pros and cons of an idea further to ensure it was the right idea at the right time.

It's a feeling many leaders can relate to. We want to move forward in a way that's calculated, with solid plans we've carefully thought through. We want to avoid risk and dodge any potential traps or pitfalls.

The problem is that we can never fully eliminate risk. As Morgan Housel writes in *Same as Ever*, risk is what is left over after we think we've thought about everything. And if we operate from the arbitrary standard that we must feel 100% confident before making a decision, we're often going to lead as if our feet are glued to the ground.

As you may remember from chapter one, leadership is not the same thing as management. We're not only concerned with keeping the system going. We want to improve the system. We want tomorrow to be better than today. And in order to experience growth, we must be comfortable with risk, knowing that there's no real innovation or progress without it.

Truth be told, this is easier for some of us than it is for others. In my work with leaders, I've found that people tend to either be naturally more reflective or more action-oriented. The reflective leader values research, information, and data. They are comfortable slowing down in conversations to think broadly and analytically. They value evidence, and they want to feel a high level of confidence about a decision before moving forward.

The action-oriented leader is more comfortable with ambiguity. They would rather ask for forgiveness than permission. They move quickly, and they don't mind taking on risks and

occasionally breaking things in the name of progress and momentum. To be honest, I see myself much more like this type of leader.

There isn't one approach that's better than the other. Like many things in life, the answer isn't fully black and white, and the truth lies somewhere in the middle. Clearly, leaders have a responsibility to gather evidence, listen to perspectives different than their own, and make wise, well-informed decisions, even if the idea that all decisions can be made with 100% is a limiting belief. Furthermore, we've probably all wrestled and agonized over decisions without a clear idea of how to best move forward. We've made pros and cons lists, we've sought wisdom from people we trust, and we've mulled over every possible outcome in pursuit of the right choice only to feel like we're still in the dark about what we should do.

I've found two lessons to be incredibly valuable for leaders who are wrestling with hard decisions. First of all, since 100% certainty isn't always possible, you must decide how certain you need to be in order to move forward.

Let's go back to my coaching conversation with the leader who was processing feedback from his supervisor. I asked him how much confidence he needed in order to make a decision. This question helped him realize that he had been consistently waiting for 100% when it wasn't always possible. Meanwhile, waiting for full certainty was actually stunting his progress rather than supporting it.

As the conversation continued, he recognized that if he felt 80% or 90% confident about something, it would be enough certainty for him to move forward. This isn't an attempt to avoid doing the work - he wasn't saying that he would stop gathering evidence or data at 80% or 90%. Instead, this was his way of recognizing that sometimes the last 10-20% isn't attainable, but it shouldn't slow him from pursuing progress or positive change for the benefit of his team.

We can reach a point where making no decision does more harm than making the wrong decision. In our pursuit of clarity, we shouldn't use fear of risk as an excuse for inaction. We must gather the facts, evidence, and data that we can, but if that doesn't paint the full picture of the decision we should make, we should still be willing to move forward in a way that reflects our values and priorities.

The other approach that's quite helpful comes in the form of a question. Before I share the question, I should call attention to the fact that the way we think about making decisions correlates with the way we often think about making changes in life.

I'm a big fan of the Deep Change model. I first heard about this model during my coursework at Coach Approach Ministries, where I did my coach training. Here's a simplistic look at the Deep Change model:

Identity > Beliefs > Actions > Results

In other words, our results are determined by our actions, which are a result of our beliefs, which are influenced by who we are (or who we desire to be). This is the reason why behavior modification doesn't lead to sustainable transformation (as James Clear beautifully explains in his best-selling book "Atomic Habits," specifically Chapter Two). In order to create true change that is sustainable, we can't simply do something different - we must become a new person who believes something different.

That's why this next lesson for leaders on making decisions packs such a punch. Next time you're faced with a challenging decision, ask yourself, what values do you want reflected in your decision?

This question is powerful because it gets us out of surface-level thinking (which is rooted in actions and results) and forces us to think deeper and more holistically about whatever it is we are doing and deciding. Of course, it also requires us to have an understanding of our values, and if you're not sure where to start, there's plenty of tools that can help. I have one on my website, and I'm also a big fan of Brene Brown's list of values from her book Dare to Lead.

For me, I consider integrity, discipline, and authenticity to be three of my top values. That's not necessarily an exhaustive list, but if I'm having a hard time deciding what to do, I can easily develop confidence if I consider how to reflect one (or more) of those three qualities in my actions.

Making hard decisions will never be "easy," especially when your decisions impact people besides yourself and might not be well-received. However, if you can become comfortable with an appropriate level of risk and root your decisions in your values and priorities, you'll be able to move forward with tough decisions and communicate them with confidence.

Furthermore, it's a lesson you can pass onto their team as well. First things first, if you can help your team gain a greater sense of what they value and why it's important to them, you will give them a gift that will produce dividends long after they leave your team or your company. We take our values with us everywhere they go, and they are a part of who we are at work as well as in our personal lives.

Additionally, you can give them confidence in making hard decisions without a clear right or wrong answer based on how it intersects with their personal values and the values of the team or company. Obviously, it's not acceptable for someone to act out of line with the company values while doing company work, even if they do so in the name of their personal values. This is a conversation you can have with them later on, and perhaps one where you use Shift Two to clarify what you don't see or what's missing from your understanding.

Perhaps you've heard the story of Herb Kelleher's famous four-word letter to a disgruntled passenger of Southwest Airlines. This particular client had grown increasingly frustrated with Southwest Airlines' lack of assigned seating and meals on flights, as well as the flight attendants' tendency to tell jokes during the safety briefings. She wrote many letters to voice her complaints, and one finally made it to the desk of Kelleher, the CEO of the company at the time.

Amazingly, he took the time to respond with a short letter to this customer that did nothing to solve her complaints, but everything to reinforce who Southwest was and what they were about. "Dear Ms. Crabapple, We will miss you. Love, Herb."

The message was clear. Southwest's core value of humor was not one they were going to sacrifice for or skimp on, even if it meant occasionally losing a customer who didn't share the value. The decision to respond to a customer in such a way that likely meant losing business was certainly not an easy one for the executive, but I imagine it was one he could make in confidence because he had a full understanding of the reason why he was doing what he was doing. The same thing is possible for you and for the people you lead. Paths will not always be clear, and risk will always be present. However, if you can train your team (and yourself) to think about the deeper reasons and values behind the decisions you're making, you'll be able to proceed with peace and confidence even when the outcome remains in question.

SHIFT FIVE

Choose Your Pain

Hopefully, by this point in the book, I've earned your trust enough to tell you how things actually are, even if it's difficult or uncomfortable to hear. If not, have I told you how nice you look today?

Enough of that, because sugar coating this likely won't help take the sting away, and if anything, it will simply diminish the impact. Here it goes.

You'll never reach a point in life where pain isn't a part of the picture.

We don't like to think about pain, and we certainly don't enjoy feeling pain. However, this doesn't change the fact that pain is a natural - and unavoidable - part of life. More importantly, there's something we can gain from the pain we experience - but only if we choose to experience the right type of pain. Pain might be uncomfortable, but in many cases, it can be quite useful.

For many years, people have summarized motivation as the desire to move toward pleasure or away from pain. Despite the context in which it's often used, motivation is neither positive nor negative: it's simply the reason why we do what we do. Motivation is present whether we're choosing to go for a run, sit on the couch, read a book, or flip through our phone.

Recently, discussions have further focused on the escape from pain as the primary driving force behind human behavior. Translation: everything we do is done in an attempt to avoid discomfort.

As someone who identifies as an optimist, I don't love this perspective, but it doesn't take away from its truth or relevance. The fact of the matter is that pain is always present, and avoiding the experience of pain is virtually impossible in every domain of life.

Knowing this, we should be less focused on avoiding pain and more focused on avoiding the wrong kind of pain.

The best kind of pain is the pain that serves a purpose. Pain, like any emotion, carries a message, but we can choose how we respond to that message. If we interpret the message correctly and choose the proper response, we can make the pain work for us rather than against us.

In my book “Motivation for Regular People: Reframing Your Drive to Pursue Your Goals and Achieve Your Potential,” I wrote that every decision in life has both a cost and a reward. Most of our internal decision dilemmas in life come when we are forced to choose between a short-term reward with a long-term cost and a long-term reward with a short-term cost.

Long-term rewards are often better, but we involuntarily gravitate toward short-term rewards because we’re able to postpone the pain until later. It’s the reason why most people would rather eat a donut today, even though they know it will make their fitness goals more challenging to reach. It’s why we avoid difficult conversations even when we know that the situation could worsen as a result of our lack of attention.

Our brains perceive any outcome that’s further in the future as uncertain and will push us to maintain a short-term state of comfort and safety rather than doing the hard thing that could result in a better tomorrow. This correlates with pain because it reminds us that either decision - whether we opt for the short-term prize or the long-term payoff - comes with some form of pain. The difference isn’t whether or not pain is present, but instead when we experience the pain and what message the pain sends us.

The short-term pain is a reminder of the greater reward that we are pursuing, while the long-term pain stirs up feelings of guilt and regret that are corrective at best and self-defeating at worst. As Craig Groeschel once said on his podcast (“The Craig Groeschel Leadership Podcast”), we can have the pain of discipline or we can have the pain of regret.

This perspective better informs how we can help somebody move past a victim mentality and move toward a place of action. When somebody is experiencing pain, it’s important that we don’t make light of this pain. We want to show up with empathy, both because it affirms the value of the person and because it provides an opportunity for the relationship to grow. I’m always amazed at how helpful presence can be in the midst of pain - whether I’m the one suffering or if I’m meeting someone who is.

Once the person feels heard and valued in their pain, we can help them think about how to productively move forward. We can ask a question that I often find helpful in coaching sessions: “What can you gain from this pain?”

This question shifts our thinking from the short-term cost to the long-term payoff. Rather than focus on what we are giving up (whether by our own choice or by no choice of our own), we identify what sort of growth or development can become possible as a result of the pain.

- The pain of waking up early to go to the gym can result in long-term discipline and a higher level of fitness if you’re willing to withstand the short-term discomfort.

- The pain of putting a few hours into your side hustle every week (outside of your regular 9-5) can lead to long-term growth and additional income - or, perhaps, your new full-time job in the future.
- The pain of having a difficult conversation with a team member at work can lead to improved performance and a better long-term relationship with that person (plus, if nothing else, you'll be more adept at having difficult conversations in the future as a result of the experience).

In each example, we must recognize that long-term success isn't possible without short-term pain. At the same time, rather than simply being an inconvenience that we would rather avoid, the pain is a tangible representation of the transformation that is happening in and around us as we gradually move toward becoming a better version of ourselves. We must remember in these moments that if we want to achieve the results that not everyone experiences, we must be willing to do the work that not everyone will do.

If our expectation is that a good life is a life without pain, we're always going to end up disappointed. On the other hand, if we think strategically about the type of pain we choose to move away from and the type of pain we are willing to accept, we will experience positive growth and transformation as we move toward the future we most want to experience.

- Choosing the pain of discomfort today will produce a positive result of growth.
- Choosing the pain of a difficult conversation today will produce a positive result of increased trust.
- Choosing the pain of rejection or embarrassment today will produce a result of learning and resilience.

Ultimately, because there's no such thing as a life without pain, everything is going to be painful in its own way. There's a degree of difficulty baked inside everything in life. Sitting down to write is difficult, but so is sitting on the couch knowing that you're not getting any closer to the book you know you need to write. Having difficult conversations with someone on your team who isn't meeting expectations is hard, but so is working on a team where there's obvious tension. Getting up early to go to the gym is hard, but so is feeling sluggish and out of shape.

Over time, if we choose the right type of pain in life, our problems may not go away, but they will become better. Most people would rather deal with the problems associated with being rich than the problems caused by being poor. I'd rather deal with being sore in the morning because I went on a long run the day before than feel like my energy and focus is lacking

because I've been missing my workouts. Everyone has problems, but some problems are certainly preferable to others.

As leaders, we have a responsibility to help our people balance optimism with pessimism. Some people will naturally lean one way over the other, but both types of thinking can be helpful in the right context. Ideally, we want to be optimistic about the long-term possibilities and potential without blinding ourselves to what progress and growth will require for us in the short-term.

To make this shift, we must educate our teams on the different types of pain that exist and the responsibility they each have to choose the type of pain they are willing to endure. Short-term pain is more noticeable, but it can produce a long-term reward. Long-term pain is easy to ignore because it can be postponed, but it doesn't lead to the innovation or impact that most of us desire. In addition, it doesn't offer a vehicle for positive growth or stretching in the same way that short-term pain can.

Pain can't be avoided, but it can be leveraged. Talking like a coach requires us to be realistic about the presence of pain, but optimistic about the value it can provide.

CONCLUSION

A Final Question for You

After writing a book on talking like a coach, it didn't feel right to end this book with a traditional conclusion.

We're almost 15,000 words into a book where I've been pounding the table telling you that it's OK to not have all the answers and to lead with more curiosity and openness. So, rather than adding more ideas on top of all the ones I've already shared with you, I'd like to end with a question. What's one outcome that would make "talking like a coach" worth it?

I bolded the word "one" on purpose. The temptation when reading a book like this one is to try and apply everything all at once. Most books we read have a lot of good information and ideas, and the temptation is to assume an all-or-nothing mentality when it comes to implementation. If we can't do everything, we feel like a failure, and as a result, we do nothing.

I'm not asking you to come up with specific instances where you'll apply each of the shifts. I'm not encouraging you to overhaul your leadership style or approach overnight. You can always come back to this book in the future to review the concepts and choose another "next step" to take, but for now, I encourage you to start with just one.

Maybe the chapter on thinking long-term was the one that most resonated with you. You've recognized that you lead a culture where putting out fires is the focus, and you want to move to a place where people are more concerned with building than maintaining. You know it will require some short-term sacrifices, but you know your future self (and your future team) will be glad you made the change.

Perhaps you've got that last chapter stuck in your mind, and you're ready to begin leveraging pain rather than avoiding it. You're not necessarily looking forward to the immediate challenge of embracing the "suck," but you know that on the other side of the "suck" is an outcome that's going to make all the work worth it.

There's a chance your takeaway has nothing to do with one of the shifts specifically, and more to do with the posture of coaching altogether. Maybe your goal going forward is to use more question marks than periods. You've realized that your black-and-white approach to conversations, emails, performance reviews, and meetings doesn't give others a chance to think deeply and express new ideas, and you're convinced that enough is enough.

I can't choose your next step for you, and more importantly, I don't want to. You know your situation (and your people) better than me, and you'll own your response more if you come up with it on your own. What matters now isn't that you follow a specific path forward, but that you commit to doing something with what you've read and learned.

Everyone is capable of talking like a coach. You don't need a credential or a coaching practice. All you need is patience, curiosity, and a belief that there's potential inside people simply waiting to be tapped into. If more people in the world were willing to lead and work this way, there's no limit to what we can accomplish together.

About the Author

Brady Ross is a leadership coach, speaker, and trainer who helps individuals and teams grow clarity, confidence, and effectiveness in the way they lead. As the founder of Clear Path Leadership, Brady specializes in practical leadership development - equipping people to lead themselves well, communicate clearly, and build healthy, high-trust teams.

Recognized as a Top 15 Coach and one of Oklahoma City's Ten Most Influential Young Professionals, Brady brings a grounded, real-world approach to leadership that resonates with emerging leaders, managers, and organizations alike. He is the author of *Motivation for Regular People* and the *Ignite Your Leadership* workbook, resources designed to make leadership growth accessible and actionable. Brady is actively invested in the leadership and coaching community, serving with Coach Approach Ministries and as a board member for ICF Arkansas-Oklahoma.

Brady has been married to his wife, Mary, for nine years, and they have two children, Bennett (7) and Norah (4). Outside of work, he enjoys golf, camping, running, and cheering on the Texas Rangers and Oklahoma City Thunder. If you're interested in connecting with Brady about coaching, training, or speaking opportunities, you can find him on LinkedIn or contact him via email at brady@bradyross.com.